

FACULTY OF HUMANITIES AND SOCIAL SCIENCE

DEPARTMENT OF COMMUNICATION STUDIES

TO	**:**	MISS. PATIENCE MPOFU
FROM	**:**	FAROOK KALUMBI
REG NUMBER	**:**	BSFAS1622
PROGRAMME	**:**	BACHELOR OF SCIENCE IN INFORMATION AND COMMUNICATION TECHNOLOGY (BICT)
LEVEL	**:**	ONE
SEMESTER	**:**	ONE
COURSE TITLE	**:**	COMMUNICATION SKILLS 1
COURSE CODE	**:**	COMM 1101
ASSIGNMENT NO	**:**	ONE
TASK	**:**	ESSAY WRITING
DUE DATE	**:**	26th FEBRUARY,2024

BARRIERS TO EFFECTIVE LISTENING

Rogers (1961) said “active listening is not merely nodding your head and making affirmative noises. It requires that you fully attend to the speaker, restate or reflect on what has been said and respond accordingly, effective listening”. Therefore, to make listening more effective, the most important thing is to be present and attentive. Nathan (2013) described effective listening as the active process of paying close attention to what someone is saying, understanding their message, and responding appropriately. It involves listening without interrupting, maintaining eye contact, and staying focused on what the speaker is saying. It also requires the listener to pay attention to nonverbal cues, like body language, and to give the speaker their full attention. When done well, effective listening can lead to improved communication. However, several barriers can hinder this process, impacting the quality of interpersonal interactions. And below paragraphs will discuss barriers to effective listening.

First and foremost, the physical barriers to listening which are also called external barriers to listening. These are obstacles that can prevent the listener from hearing and understand the speaker. According to Schramm (1996) described only three main physical barriers to effective listening, he firstly goes on to list with noise as one of the physical barriers to listening. Loud noise like constructions, traffic or music can make one to get it difficult to hear what the speaker is saying. He also added that the distance is also physical barrier to effective listening. This happens if the listener is too far away from the speaker and it becomes hard for the listener to hear what the speaker is saying. He concluded with the interruption, like phone calls or other people in the room, this can take the listeners attention away from the speaker. In line with Schramm, this physical barriers to effective listening affects listening process, as this barrier causes the listener to miss important information or misunderstand the message. Additionally, frustration caused by the physical barrier can lead to a loss of interest in the message, making it even harder. However, (Schulz,1969) explained several strategies that can be used to overcome physical barriers to effective listening. First, the listener should improve the physical environment by reducing noise and moving to quite place. Finally, the listener should listen actively and pay attention to speaker’s body language and gesture.

Mental barriers to listening is also a major barriers to effective listening. These are psychological factors that interfere with the ability to listen. (DeVito and Hecht) observed that mental barriers to effective listening can affect listening in three ways. First, the attention of the listener. This mental barrier can interfere with listeners ability to pay attention to the speaker and this may lead to the listeners to miss important information or misinterpreting what the speaker is saying. Additionally, is the retention of the listener. This mental barrier can make a listener to get it difficult to remember what the speaker has said. Then it becomes hard for the listener to understand the message or respond appropriately. Finally, interpretation of the listener. this mental barrier can cause a listener to misinterpret the speaker. However (Anderson,1996) discussed several ways of overcoming mental barriers to effective listening. One strategy is to take notes while listening, which can help to improve attention and retention. Another strategy is to use active listening skills, such as to paraphrase or repeat back what the speaker has said. Finally, it is important to focus on the speaker message, rather than on your own thoughts or feeling.

Furthermore, cultural barriers are also one of the barriers to effective listening. (Evans,2006) described cultural barriers to effective listening as difference in cultural rules and patterns of communication that can create misunderstandings. He also provided numerous examples of the barriers and one of them is difference in verbal and nonverbal communication styles. Cultural barriers have a significant impact on the listening process. According to Gumperz (1982) argues that different cultural backgrounds can lead to different assumptions about the meaning of certain words or gestures hence creating a misunderstanding. Different in communication styles that different cultures have also led to difficulties in understanding each other hence also affecting listening process. We can overcome cultural barriers to effective listening by developing a cultural awareness by understanding the cultural norms and expectations of the speaker, in such a way that it helps to avoid misunderstandings and misinterpretations. However, (Tannen,2002) recommends using cultural brokers or people who are knowledgeable about both cultures and can mediate communication between speakers from different cultures.

Last but one, another barrier to effective listening is the listeners attitude. This refers to listeners mindset and emotional state while listening to another person. According to (Zemach,1990)

described the listeners attitude as a barrier to effective listening and he states that attitude is major factor to determining how we listen. He explains that positive attitude helps the listener to approach a conversation with curiosity and desire to understand. On the other hand a negative attitude will hinder understanding. There are number of strategies that can be used to overcome a negative attitude in listeners. However (Goulston,2010) recommends that the listeners should ask questions to clarify and confirm understanding. This allows listener to show that they are actively listening and interested in what the speaker is saying. Finally, he also recommends to use active listening techniques such as paraphrasing, reflecting and summarizing. This helps the listener to gain a deeper understanding of the message.

Lastly, language barriers are also barriers to effective listening. These occurs when the listener and the speaker speak different language or have different levels of language proficiency. Lutz (1980) emphasizes that language differences can lead to misunderstanding, frustration, and even conflict. When language barriers exist between the listener and the speaker, it can affect listening process. In such a way that it creates a communication frustration, as the listener may not be able to fully comprehend the speaker culture. As the result, the listener may miss important cultural cues and have difficulty in understanding the speakers intended message. To overcome language barriers to effective listening, there are several strategies that can be used. According to (Duke,2010) suggests using active listening skills as one of the strategies, such as paraphrasing and asking questions for clarification. She also suggests developing cultural knowledge and sensitivity, which can help to bridge language barriers and improve understanding.

In summary, there are several barriers to effective listening. The physical barrier, emotional barriers, psychological barriers, cultural barriers and language barriers, are the barriers to effective listening as discussed in the context. Meanwhile, the above paragraphs have also discussed about the impact of these barriers to listening process which include miss understanding the message, missing important information and conflict. The listeners are able to overcome with barriers to effective by improving physical environment, using active listening skills and also using cultural brokers.

References

Anderson, D.R., & Anderson, R.L. (1996). *Overcoming barriers to effective listening*. New York, NY: McGraw-Hill companies, Inc.

Duke, L.C. (2010). *Communicating effectively is diverse world*. Los Angeles, CA: Sage publications, Inc.

DeVito, A.J., & Hecht, W.R. (1994). *Communication processes*. New York, NY: HarperCollins College Publishers.

Goulston, M., & Goldberg, P. (2010). *Active listening: Improve your relationships one conversation at a time*. New York, NY: Jossey-Bass.

Gumperz, J. J. (1993). *Cultural differences and misunderstandings*. In J. J. Gumperz & S. C. Levinson (Eds.), Rethinking linguistic relativity (pp.144-166). Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University press.

Lutz, R.J. (1980/2008). *Verbal communication (4th ed.)*. Boston, MA: Wadsworth.

Schulz, W. L. (2006). *Active listening: Improve your relationships one conversation at a time*. New York, NY: McGraw-Hill.

Schramm, W. (1956). *The use of language in the classroom*. New York, NY: Harper & Row.

Zemach, E., & Seewald, D. (1990). *Communicating effectively: Overcoming barriers and bridging distances*. Boston, MA: Heinle & Heinle.